



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times
PACIFIC COAST Highway in Malibu shows lingering scars of the Palisades fire in a drone photo Tuesday.

Six months after the fires, progress is painful and hard

Cleanup, investigations and lawsuits continue after the disaster

By Hannah Fry, Tony Briscoe and Richard Winton

The signs of change are there, if you look hard enough. Hillsides along the Pacific Ocean, burned beyond recognition, are showing tentative signs of rebirth. The occasional flower is blooming next to a lost home. From the air, the grid of Altadena shows acres of neatly graded empty lots where the burned-out remains of homes and businesses stood. The fresh wood frame of a new home in Pacific

Palisades has become a beacon of hope for some. But the six-month milestone of the worst firestorm in Los Angeles County history still feels hard to measure. The feelings of loss — 30 deaths, thousands of homes gone, long-term plans derailed, battles with insurance companies, mental anguish — are still too raw. And evidence of progress still feels too fleeting to take much comfort in, especially for the thousands of victims. Modern Los Angeles has never experienced loss on this scale, so there are no easy road maps. There are the indi-

vidual challenges: Struggling with the death of loved ones, determining whether to rebuild, and assessing the financial losses. Then there are the collective ones: Will my neighborhood ever feel like my neighborhood again? Can I afford to still live here? Do I still want to live here? For all the uncertainty, there have been some measurable changes since January. Thousands of lots have been cleared. Numerous lawsuits have been filed. Multiple investigations are underway and dozens of new building permits have been issued. [See Fires, A14]

Will tax credits help soundstage owners?

By Roger Vincent and Samantha Masunaga

The announcement last month that Occidental Studios would be put up for sale marked a historic turning point in a studio that was once used by Mary Pickford and Douglas Fairbanks to

make silent films. It also underscored how dramatically the market has shifted for the owners of soundstages across Los Angeles that have been buffeted by a confluence of forces — the pandemic, strikes in 2023 and the continued flight of production to other states and coun-

tries. As film activity has fallen to historic levels in the L.A. region — film shoot days dropped 22% in the first quarter of 2025 — the places that host film and TV crews, along with prop houses and other businesses that service the industry, have been especially hard hit.

Between 2016 and 2022, Los Angeles' soundstages were nearly filled to capacity, boasting average occupancy rates of 90%, according to data from the nonprofit organization FilmLA, which tracks on-location shoot days in the Greater L.A. area. [See Soundstages, A11]

White House sees raids as a 'grand success'

Moves against L.A. excite Trump's base. But polls, a legal case could spoil the party.

By Michael Wilner

WASHINGTON — National Guard troops and immigration agents on horseback, clad in green uniforms and tactical gear, trotted into MacArthur Park on Monday, surrounding the iconic square with armored vehicles in a show of force widely denounced as gratuitous. The enforcement operation produced few tangible results that day. But the purpose of the display was unmistakable. The Trump administration's monthlong operation in Los Angeles, which began on June 6 with flash raids at worksites and culminated days later with President Trump's deployment of Marines and the Guard, continues to pay political dividends to a president who had been in search of the perfect foil on his signature issue since retaking office, officials close to the president told The Times. At first, officials in the West Wing thought the operation might last only a week or two. But Trump's team now says the ongoing spec-

tacle has proved a resounding political success with few downsides. Thus far, the administration has managed to fend off initial court challenges, maintain arrests at a steady clip, and generate images of a ruthless crackdown in a liberal bastion that delight the president's supporters. It may be premature for the president to declare political victory. Anger over the operation has swelled, prompting activism across California. And signs have emerged that the White House may be misreading Trump's election mandate and the political moment, with new polls showing public sentiment turning nationwide on the president's increasingly aggressive enforcement tactics. The city has struggled to cope, hobbled by an unpopular mayor and a nationally divisive governor who have been unable to meaningfully respond to the unprecedented federal effort. But the raids have also provided California's Democratic governor, Gavin Newsom, with an opportunity to fill a leadership vacuum as his party grapples to find its footing in the resistance. Lawsuits could still change the course of the operation. A crucial hearing set for Thursday in a case that could challenge the consti- [See Immigration, A6]



AL SEIB For The Times
IN CAMARILLO, workers plant jalapeños. Recent immigration raids are keeping many out of the fields.

Stephen Miller's L.A. revenge plot plays out

Renewed attention is being paid to White House deputy chief of staff's Santa Monica upbringing

By Julia Wick

On a palm tree-lined bluff overlooking the Pacific Ocean, thousands of people rallied against the Trump administration in one of many "No Kings Day" protests around the country last month. Here in Santa Monica, the well-heeled and beachy protesters also had a localized message: America, we're sorry. "Santa Monica apologizes for Stephen Miller," a bearded man in a straw hat proclaimed via hand-scrawled poster board. "Stephen Miller, who

raised you?" another protester inquired in purple puff paint. Others paired the White House deputy chief of staff's name with expletives. Amid the false accusations and acrid clashes of President Trump's inner circle, few acolytes have survived longer than Miller. The 39-year-old has remained essential through Trump's second term, piloting an immigration platform that has sowed fear across wide swaths of the country — nowhere more so than Greater Los Angeles, where federal agents have mounted a relentless assault on immigrants, sweep- [See Miller, A7]



CHIP SOMODEVILLA Getty Images
STEPHEN MILLER, who attended Santa Monica High, has combated L.A.'s liberal scene for years.

For state's farmers, migrant laborers are 'irreplaceable'

Trump official insists Medicaid recipients and machines can do all the work instead.

By Andrea Castillo, Suhauna Hussain and Jessica Garrison

A top Trump administration official's claim that Medicaid recipients could replace farmworkers has met with pushback from California's agriculture industry, which faces the loss of its workforce amid the federal immigration crackdown. "There will be no amnesty. The mass deporta-

tions continue, but in a strategic way," said Agriculture Secretary Brooke Rollins at a news conference in Washington, D.C., on Tuesday. "And we move the workforce towards automation and 100% American participation, which, again, with 34 million people, able-bodied adults on Medicaid, we should be able to do that fairly quickly." Helen McGrath, whose family farms citrus and avocados in Ventura County, said Rollins' comments were insulting. "I can confidently say that most farmers in the country either laughed out loud or were just deflated by those comments," she said. "It just shows how unin- [See Agriculture, A6]

Feral bees crowd out native species
California pollinators are being overwhelmed by an exploding population of European bees. **SCIENCE, A8**

State is sued over trans athletes
Trump administration's suit targets California's policy on high school sports. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 92/65. **B6**

Markets A11
Opinion Voices A12

CEO of Musk's X is stepping down
Linda Yaccarino led the social media company through a period of tumult. **BUSINESS, A9**

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A lawman on the surface, but El Diablo underneath

By Patrick J. McDonnell

MEXICO CITY — By his own admission, the Mexican lawman known as El Diablo — the Devil — supervised a scourge of torture, murder, kidnappings, land grabs and other abuses while amassing a fortune in cartel bribes that bankrolled purchases of homes, cattle and a fleet of buses. Edgar Veytia's transgres-

sions came while he was the top cop in Nayarit, a small Pacific Coast state that evolved from a sleepy backwater to one of Mexico's most violent cartel battlegrounds. Veytia, who honed the public persona of a crusading, pistol-packing prosecutor, brazenly traveled between Mexico and the United States, confident that no one would see beyond his righteous, tough-on-crime facade.

"I didn't think I would be arrested," Veytia testified later. His sense of invulnerability was shattered on March 27, 2017, when U.S. agents busted Veytia at a border crossing in San Diego. This was no low-level mule who ferried drugs on his person, but a state attorney general who had facilitated cartel smuggling for years. Veytia pleaded guilty in January 2019 to narcotics trafficking. El Diablo, however, knew

where the bodies were buried — a knowledge he peddled tirelessly to his U.S. handlers. And when he testified against an even bigger Mexican narco-politician, he secured a get-out-of-jail card — before completing even half of his 20-year U.S. prison sentence. Veytia, 55, was released from prison in February and is currently a free man, residing in the northeastern United States. But now he is [See El Diablo, A4]